with the girls in the school. I was impressed by how their aspirations had grown. One girl told me she wanted to be an astronaut like Kalpana Chawla, another said she wanted to be like me—become the governor of the Reserve Bank. I do hope that in not too distant a future, the Reserve Bank will be headed by a female governor with a rural background.

While the outreach programme was widely commended, there were a few critics who said that an initiative like this was out of character for a central bank which should remain in the background, and see and learn quietly. There was criticism also that there was too much of show and festivity and that it was just a vacuous attempt by the Reserve Bank to play to the gallery, and had little learning value. I remained sensitive to this criticism and was concerned that the outreach programme should not degenerate into an empty pageant; that it should retain its freshness and spontaneity, and continue to enrich the Reserve Bank's collective understanding of the sociological context of our policies. Just to make sure that we remained on track, I frequently did a reality check with the senior management, both in formal meetings as well as informal conversations.

Town Hall Meetings

Although I have gone on at length on the outreach programme, this was only one of the several initiatives that we launched during my tenure at the Reserve Bank in order to keep our ears close to the ground.

The town hall meetings I wrote about earlier were a particularly rich hunting ground for insights and understanding. I recall vividly the very first town hall meeting we held in Chennai, on the steps of the museum in Egmore, one pleasant January evening, as part of the Reserve Bank's platinum jubilee celebration. This was shortly before Pongal in 2010, and Chennai was in a festive mood, matching with the celebratory mood of the Reserve Bank's platinum jubilee. Vikram Chandra of NDTV was the moderator, and seated on the dais along with me were the four deputy governors—Shyamala Gopinath, Usha Thorat, K.C. Chakrabarty and Subir